

Tenrecs and golden moles

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Mammalia
ORDER	Afrosoricida
FAMILIES	2
SPECIES	51

Genetic studies show that tenrecs and golden moles, which were once classified with shrews, moles, and hedgehogs, are actually unrelated to them. The Madagascan tenrecs (and semiaquatic African otter shrews) include species that are unusual among mammals in having a reptilian cloaca: a common opening to the anus and the urinogenital tract. They feed mainly on invertebrates. The African golden moles have strong limbs for burrowing, tiny skin-covered eyes, and lack external ears. They prey on underground animals, such as earthworms and burrowing lizards.

NOCTURNAL HUNTER

At night, Grant's golden moles forage for food on the surface, feeding mainly on termites. They will, however, eat a wide variety of invertebrates, and small lizards too, if they can catch them. Here, Grant's golden mole feasts on a locust.



Tenrec ecaudatus

Common tenrec



Location Madagascar

Length 10–15½ in (26–39 cm)

Tail ¾–½ in (1–1.5 cm)

Weight 3¼–5½ lb (1.5–2.5 kg)

Social unit Individual

Status Least concern



The 30 species of tenrecs are mainly from central Africa and Madagascar. Most resemble a combination of shrew and hedgehog. The nocturnal,



common tenrec is the largest land-dwelling species. It has coarse, gray to reddish gray fur and sharp spines. Using its long, mobile snout, it grubs among leaves for worms and other small creatures. It also scavenges and hunts frogs and mice. In defense, a tenrec squeals, erects the spiny hairs on its neck into a crest, jumps and bucks, and readily bites. It shelters by day in a nest of grass and leaves under a log, rock, or bush. After a gestation of 56–64 days, a litter of 1–32 is born, averaging at about 18. When young, common tenrecs are striped black and white.

Micropotamogale lamottei

Nimba otter-shrew



Location W. Africa (Mount Nimba area)

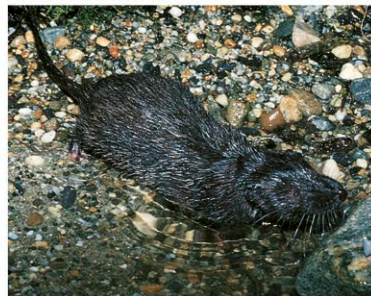
Length 4¾–8 in (12–20 cm)

Tail 4–6 in (10–15 cm)

Weight 4¾ oz (135 g)

Social unit Individual

Status Near threatened



This otter-shrew is largely restricted to upland forest streams in an area of about 580 square miles (1,500 square km) around Mount Nimba in West Africa. It has a fleshy nose, rounded head, compact body, and long tail. Long, gray or dark brown fur usually hides the eyes and most of the ears. It is mostly nocturnal, catching small fish, crabs, water insects, and similar prey on short dives or along river banks, and eating them on land. It digs a short nesting burrow in soft soil.

Hemicentetes semispinosus

Lowland streaked-tenrec



Location Madagascar

Length 6½–7½ in (16–19 cm)

Tail None

Weight 2½–10½ oz (80–280 g)

Social unit Group

Status Least concern



This species is distinguished from other tenrecs by its two-tone color of background black with variable stripes of white, yellow, or brown. The fur is coarse with scattered spines and a patch of spiky hairs on the crown, which is erect as a crest. The main foods are worms and grubs. The streaked tenrec lives in groups of 15 or more, and all help to protect each female's litter of 2–11 young.



Limnogale mergulus

Web-footed tenrec



Location E. Madagascar

Length 4¾–6½ in (12–17 cm)

Tail 4¾–6½ in (12–16 cm)

Weight 2½–3¼ oz (62–90 g)

Social unit Individual

Status Vulnerable



Once believed extinct, the only aquatic species of tenrec has been relocated in the wild but information is very scarce. It has an otterlike form, with long whiskers, small high-set eyes and ears, and webbed

rear feet with sharp claws, used to grip slippery rocks and prey. Compared to other tenrecs, it has a broad, round-muzzled head. The short, dense, water-repellent fur is reddish brown. The web-footed tenrec noses among stones and weeds for water insects, crabs, and crayfish, propelled mainly by means of its long, scantily haired tail.



ears barely visible in fur

Potamogale velox

Giant otter-shrew



Location W. and C. Africa

Length 11½–14 in (29–35 cm)

Tail 9½–35 in (24–90 cm)

Weight 12½–14 oz (340–397 g)

Social unit Individual

Status Least concern



Easily mistaken at a glance for a small otter (which is a mustelid rather than an insectivore), the giant otter-shrew

has a rounded muzzle, a long, flexible body, and a long, muscular tail flattened from side to side, which it uses to propel itself through water. This species inhabits a variety of freshwater habitats, from still pools to mountain torrents at altitudes of 6,000 ft (1,800 m). The eyes and ears are small and high-set, for swimming low in the water; yet, unlike an otter, the toes lack webs. Mainly nocturnal and solitary outside the breeding season, the giant otter-shrew hunts primarily at night for fish, frogs, shellfish, and other freshwater animals. Its bankside burrow, where it shelters by day, has an underwater entrance.